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The significance of Osip Mandelstam for Paul Celan*

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ABSTRACT
This article follows the development of Celan's poetic quest in order to understand why, since the late 1950s, he felt close to Osip Mandelstam's poetics, as well as to Martin Heidegger's thoughts on language and finitude, and Martin Buber's dialogism. Although his relationship to Heidegger and Buber has been at the centre stage of Celan studies for decades, the importance of his readings of Mandelstam have not been sufficiently attended to. Understanding his connection to Mandelstam and Russian acmeism can illuminate more profoundly the role Heidegger and Buber play in his reflections on poetics. The way acmeists 'digested', to use an anthropophagic term, Baudelaire's symbolism, was critical for Celan to value a poetics of existence over a poetics of formal experimentation, the latter is what his contemporaries were interested in exploring as they followed Mallarme's legacy, criticised by Celan in *The Meridian* speech he gave in 1960.

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I

Delivered on 22 October 1960, *The Meridian* is considered Celan's 'most important and extended statement on poetics [and is where] the theoretical base of the changes from the early to the late work'[1] is to be found. It has influenced writers, poets, artists and philosophers from many parts of the world by not only reasserting the importance of addressing the other, but also of putting into question the language in which we do this as well as the conditions of possibility of address and reception. This article follows the development of Celan's poetic quest in order to understand why he felt close to Osip Mandelstam's poetics, as well as to Martin Heidegger's thoughts on language and finitude, and Martin Buber's dialogism. His connection to these authors' works led to the ideas developed in *The Meridian* about the poem being a receptive, yet incomplete, moment of encounter.

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Over the last 20 years scholars have started to acknowledge the extent to which Celan's readings and translations of Mandelstam's essays and poems played a role in the development of his own poetics (Ryland, 2010; Glazova, 2008; Eskin, 2000). His presence is especially discernible in the period in which he drafted *The Meridian*. Michael Eskin recalls that the Russian poet's work 'had a profound impact on Celan's poetry following the publication of *Sprachgitter* [1959] (…) and, most significantly, on his poetic cycle *Die Niemandsrose* [1963]',[2] which is dedicated to him. Therefore, it is necessary to pay close attention to Celan's engagement with Mandelstam's work in order to reflect critically on his poetics after 1959.[3]

Martin Heidegger and Martin Buber also influenced him strongly: the first in relation to finitude and the second regarding poetic address. Celan's library held fifteen books written by Buber and three about him. His first recorded reading of this Jewish dialogist dates back to 1940; they finally met in 1960, in what has since been known to have truly been a failed encounter, unlike the one with Heidegger in 1967 which has been distorted and misinterpreted.[4] Celan's first readings of Heidegger date back to 1951 and continue until his death in 1970. There were more books by Heidegger in his library than by any other author.

Since Celan's relationship with the works of Heidegger and Buber have been studied more thoroughly by contemporary philosophers and literary theorists than his readings of Mandelstam, I will begin with and expand more in regard to the latter.[5]

II

Paul Celan was born on the 23 of November 1920 in Czernowitz, Romania. This city was taken by the Red Army in 1940, by the Nazis in 1941, and again by the Soviets in 1944. His Jewish parents were murdered in the Transnistria death camp in 1942 and he endured two years of forced labour in Moldavia until released in 1944. He then moved from Czernowitz to Bucharest and Vienna; during this time, he changed his name from Antschel to Celan and published his famous poem '*Todesfuge*'. It was published in a Romanian translation, since he originally wrote it in German, the language that Fritzi Antschel, his mother, loved and insisted on being spoken at home; even though the family also spoke Romanian, Ukrainian and Yiddish. After Vienna, he moved to Paris and lived there from 1948 until 1970, when he jumped from the Pont Mirabeau into the Seine. It took nine days to find his body.

I cannot help connecting the image of his death with the presence of stones, which is surely indebted to the idea of sinking, as well as to the Jewish tradition of putting small stones on graves. But it is also indebted to Celan's proximity with Mandelstam, who famously proclaimed that words had to 'return the stoneness to the stone!' With this proclamation

Mandelstam defined one of the main characteristics of acmeism: to treat poems as events that disclose existence. In Celan's own words: '[a]cm.<eism>: To lead language into closeness with being'.[6]

Acmeism is a literary movement from the Silver Age of Russian poetry, which refers to the symbolist and post-symbolist movements (acmeism and futurism) that developed in Russia in the late nineteenth century and throughout the twentieth. The emergence of the 'Elder' symbolists 'was marked by Merezhkovsky's collection of poems (…) *Symbols* (1893)'.[7] The primary source for the concept of the symbol that was incorporated into this literary tradition was Charles Baudelaire's poem 'Correspondences' (1857). Mandelstam refers to this poem directly in his essay 'Morning of Acmeism': 'We do not want to distract ourselves with a stroll through the 'forest of symbols' because we have a denser, more virgin forest-divine physiology, the infinite complexity of our own dark organism'.[8] With these words he responds to the Russian symbolists, and also to one of the main precursors of modernism, Baudelaire himself. This passage brings down to earth the 'forest of symbols' that 'Correspondences' describes as having 'the power to expand into infinity'. Acmeists aren't concerned with expanding to the infinite, but with retraction, concentration, attention to what already exists *temporally*, like our own dark organism.

According to the scholar Gasparov, in 'Correspondences':

> The symbols flutter with metamorphoses, showing themselves in a variety of appearances – as colors, sounds, odors, whose suggestive and elusive resemblances (or 'correspondences') carry the promise of an ultimate wholeness of the transcendent realm of the spirit, which finds in them fragmented and scattered representations.[9]

Thus, for a symbolist, 'any particular phenomenon appears to be wrapped in a web of associations'; things do not exist for their own sake but 'as a means for spreading echoes into the infinite'.[10] For Mandelstam, the problem is specifically that symbolist poetry bifurcates the sign in a transcendent maze that seeks what lies beyond the limits of human experience and beyond the existence of the things themselves. In a later essay, 'On the Nature of the Word' (1922), he describes the problem with symbolism as follows: 'Perception is demoralized. Nothing is real, genuine. Nothing is left but a terrifying quadrille of 'correspondences', all nodding to one another. Eternal winking. (…) The rose nods to the girl, the girl to the rose. No one wants to be himself'.[11] On this account it's not surprising that acmeism was initially to be called 'adamism' in order to stress 'the directness of meaning with which Adam had originally bestowed names on all the phenomena around him'.[12] Instead they chose acmeism, which locates the movement within a modernist tradition: the Greek word acme (ἀκμή) refers to the pinnacle, cutting edge or foremost state and, in this context, it stands as an 'allegiance to the upper crust of

meaning, in contradistinction to the symbolists metaphysical depths' (ibid.). In a study on the reception of *Baudelaire in Russia*, Adrian Wanner writes: 'the acmeists rejected the symbolist quest for transcendence in favor of a clearly delineated depiction of earthly reality (…) Baudelaire had to be understood as a sort of pre-acmeist'.[13]

It is important to consider why Baudelaire was the chosen interlocutor in this dialogue between the Russians (symbolists as well as post symbolists) and the French symbolists. Wanner affirms that he 'was virtually the only French poet who played a significant role in the Russian decadence of the 1890s and also in the symbolist movement of the 1900s'.[14] He was an attentive observer of modern life, and his system of correspondences reacted to the development of the city, to the loss of the sacred and to the opening of the profane – in society and in literature. His work represents an epoch in which values shifted in different ways that were more than familiar to the Russians, whose window to a secular modernity was open since Peter the Great whilst, at the same time, power and social order were preserved in old fashioned ways for a very long time.

To have a window open onto the rapidly changing ways of the West at the same time as power was still in the hands of the Tsarist autocracy shaped a strange and anachronistic society in which the forces of the transitory and the eternal, of the profane and the sacred, were in tension. The result: inequality, poverty and injustice. Therefore, for the Russian 'painters of modern life' art was also a means to question, represent and transform the values of an epoch, but unlike the French symbolists, they also represented a constant threat to the instituted orders. As we know, Pushkin, Lermontov, Tsvetaeva and Mandelstam are only some of the names of writers who lived in exile at least once either under the Tsarist or the Soviet regimes. In fact, the first poet to translate Baudelaire into Russian was Pyotr Filippovich Yakubovich (1860–1911), a revolutionary poet who was serving time in Siberia. According to Wanner, 'Baudelaire's poetic revolution was largely ignored by his early Russian translators, who seemed mainly preoccupied with the alleged "message" of his poems'.[15] This is significant because it shows us that the Russians were first drawn to Baudelaire politically.[16] However, the emphasis shifted with the symbolists.

Baudelaire is also an important pre-acmeist reference for Mandelstam, because even though the acmeists rejected the transcendent element of symbolist correspondences, they transformed this web of associations into another type of web: a cultural one. To raise 'a phenomenon to the tenth power',[17] poets must take into account all the cultural echoes and meanings that determine it:

> … the proclaimed return to substances did not mean […] that what acmeists promoted was only direct, unmediated meanings. For them, "tangible"

> meant grounded in culture. A word might resound with a multitude of meanings, provided that each of them could be placed in its authentic cultural "home".[18]

Mandelstam's acmeism privileges the correspondences between these cultural 'homes' over the words' content. This is why he writes: 'Love the existence of the thing more than the thing itself and your own existence more than yourself: that is acmeism's highest commandment'.[19] It is only in existence that we hear the world resonating.

We must keep this in mind to adequately understand why Celan defines acmeism as a way that leads language into closeness with being. A line from a poem included in *Snowpart* says: 'I hear the stone stand in you'.[20] Here the speaker of the poem stresses the singularity of the addressee's existence. The image of the stone represents the real, the genuine and the perceivable (as defined by Mandelstam). At the same time, the line stresses the phenomenality of words themselves. In German 'stone' and 'stand' are phonetically similar; consequently, the line '*hör ich den Stein in dir stehn*' also suggests that the word '*Stein*' can be heard in the word '*stehn*'. If we read them aloud we hear that their only difference lies in the way the vowels sound, which in English can be pronounced as – i – and – ee – respectively. This gives rise to a polysemic play of correspondences amongst both words and the reader they address.

The centrality that Celan gives to this type of 'existential correspondences' explains why he felt closer to Mandelstam than to most of his German contemporaries, who are best represented by the figure of Gottfried Benn. In 1951, Benn gave a lecture on lyric poetry in which he claimed poetry was monological and also reconnected postwar German poetry with the European tradition through the figure of Mallarmé. Celan scholars agree that *The Meridian* is partly a response and a rejection of Benn's ideas. For Celan, Mallarmé's legacy is formalist and impersonal; it prioritises the materiality of the word over address and finite existence, matters that Celan claims poetry must deal with in response to the catastrophe of his epoch. In *The Meridian*, which revolves around four works by Georg Büchner, we find a statement in which he relates postwar German poetry to how Mallarmé has been received:

> Doesn't Büchner (…) propose (…) a truly radical calling-into-question of art? (…) A calling-into-question to which all of today's poetry has to return if we want to question further? (…) [M]ay we, as happens in many places these days, start from art as something given and absolutely unconditional, should we before all, to put it most concretely, think – let's say – Mallarmé through to the end?[21]

For Celan, calling 'today's poetry' into question implies that Mallarmé's reception should be called into question. In a draft note of the speech he

describes the difference between his own poetic quest and the French poet's legacy:

> In the poem: that, I believe, does not mean (…), n'en déplaise à Mallarmé, in one of those phonetically, semantically and syntactically over-differentiated language structures assembled from "words" (…). Not in the poem that sees itself as "word music"; not in any "mood poetry" woven from various "timbres" (…) not in the poem as a result of word-creations, word-concretions, word-destructions, word-games; not in any new "expressive art form"; nor in the poem as in a "second" reality that would heighten the real symbolically. (…) Rather in the poem as the poem of the one who speaks under the angle of inclination of his Being ….[22]

This categorical list describes the aspects of Mallarmé's poetics that Celan's contemporaries inherited, transformed and reproduced – lyric poets like Benn himself, or the concrete poets (whose first German speaking poet was Eugen Gomringer). Celan resisted this plastic and lyric approach to poetry because his writing was motivated by a concern with temporality, finitude and pain, which demanded a reflection on the complexities of language and communication in the aftermath of the Holocaust. In the *Bremen Address* he stated that, in the midst of losses, language remained:

> But it had to pass through its own answerlessness, pass through a frightful muting, pass through the thousand darknesses of death bringing speech. It passed through and gave back no words for that which happened; yet it passed through this happening. Passed through and could come to light again, "enriched" by all this.[23]

One should always have this passage in mind when approaching Celan's work. The change his poetics goes through is a matter of orientation in a language that stopped speaking and only brought death upon the world. He defines this 'frightful muting' as an *answerlessness*, as if this death bringing speech were a one-sided speech with no need for interlocutors. The other was not given a chance to answer. It is important to stress that at this point Celan's diagnosis of language and discourse under Nazism is that it lacks response and reception. In the years before 1958, starting with the publication of '*Todesfuge*' in 1947, Celan confronts the Holocaust by addressing issues like the memory of the dead, the community that died, murder, mourning and suffering, but in time his reflection stops giving centrality to meaning and is reoriented to poetic address and reception. This is one of the main reasons he is drawn to the Russian poet. Celan finds a way to start answering to his contemporaries, and to the Holocaust, with Mandelstam's critique and transformation of symbolism into existential resonances.

In a draft note from *The Meridian* he writes: 'The poems of Osip Mandelstam are the poems of someone who perceives, attentively, turned toward what appears (…) questioning and addressing what appears; they are

conversation'.[24] Here he brings up two main aspects of his own poetics. First, that response or receptivity are tied to the perception of what appears before us – for Celan, this refers to the singular utterance of the poem, and the senses that are privileged are seeing and hearing. Second: the question of dialogue. The condition of possibility in both cases is address, to address one another. And what gives address existential resonance (instead of, say, the means of transmission of a message) is the awareness of finitude that comes with it.

In 1960 Celan wrote to Herman Kasack: 'Aren't poems exactly this? The infinite-saying of mortality and nothingness that remains mindful of its finitude'.[25] The idea of the infinite conjoined by a hyphen to the action of saying grounds the infinite and refers it to the action of repeating over and over again. Furthermore, what is being said repeatedly is about limits: to be aware of finitude and nothingness. This is at the heart of Celan's work from 1959 on: it discloses the finitude of who is speaking, of who is spoken to, and of the way in which poetic language speaks – mindful of mortality. This is the core element of his poetics, because along with the awareness of finitude comes the singularity and difference of each being.

In this line of thought, he also developed the idea that poems were not a means to inform or send a message ('Poems: no "message" no "information"' he wrote in a note from *The Meridian*[26]). This determined the rest of his work and serves as another explanation of his tense, broken and resistant language. In an article written only one year after Celan's death, Lyon already described some aspects that had changed since he had first started writing as follows: 'reduction of long lines to monosyllabic lines; drastic reduction in length of poems; elimination of most titles; disappearance of dream imagery … '.[27]

The end of a poem from *Die Niemandsrose*, 'Tübingen, January', describes this language at its extreme point:

Came, if there
came a man,
came a man to the world, today, with
the patriarchs'
light-beard: he could,
if he spoke of this
time, he
could
only babble and babble
every- ever-
moremore.

("Pallaksch. Pallaksch.")[28]

Pallaksch is a stutter that was invented by Hölderlin when he was living in a tower in Tübingen and had let his beard grow in the light of the Patriarchs.

He used the word to say yes or no.[29] It's more like a sound than a word, but it is a word and it has no unique meaning. *Pallaksch* breaks up the sign: it is a signifier without a definite signified. In this sense it is very similar to a word that Primo Levi recalls in his testimony *If This is a Man*, which was pronounced by a young boy named Hurbinek whom he encountered at the death camp: *massklo*. Giorgio Agamben cites this part of Levi's testimony and comments it as follows:

> They all listen and try to decipher that sound (…) but, despite the presence of all the languages of Europe in the camp, Hurbinek's word remains obstinately secret. "No, it was certainly not a message, it was not a revelation; perhaps it was his name, if it had ever fallen to his lot to be given a name; perhaps (…) it meant 'to eat' or 'bread;' or perhaps 'meat' (…). Hurbinek, the nameless (…). Nothing remains of him: he bears witness through these words of mine". (Levi 1986:192)

> Perhaps this was the secret word that Levi discerned in the "background noise" of Celan's poetry. And yet in Auschwitz, Levi nevertheless attempted to listen to that which no one has borne witness, to gather the secret word: *mass-klo* or *matisklo*. Perhaps every word, every writing is born, in this sense, as a testimony. This is why what is borne witness to cannot already be language or writing. It can only be something to which no one has borne witness. (…) And this is the sound that arises from the lacuna, the non-language that one speaks when one is alone, the non-language to which language answers (…) It is necessary to reflect on the nature of that to which no one has borne witness, on this non-language.[30]

For Celan, *massklo* or *pallaksch* is the path that poetry must follow. It bears witness to singularity; it shares what cannot be communicated in its very resistance. In the context of testimony, Celan, like Levi, is concerned with stepping away from historical facts that, despite being extremely important in terms of legality, justice and official recognition, don't account for pain. Their language is closer to the 'non-language', which is common to both testimonies and poetry. In this direction we may understand an affirmation made by Derrida in 'Politics and Poetics of Witnessing', according to which every testimony entails an experience of poetic language,[31] an unredeemable darkness. This is important because it allows us to see that there is something specific to the poetic function that also characterises the language of bearing witness: this is, that language is also non-communicative. Even though Celan's position in this regard is undoubtedly an effect of the linguistic aftermath of the Holocaust, he encounters a theoretical explication for it in Heidegger's 'The Nature of Language', which he read in 1959[32]:

> But when does language speak itself as language? Curiously enough, when we cannot find the right word for something that concerns us, carries us away,

> oppresses us or encourages us. Then we leave unspoken what we have in mind and, without rightly giving it thought, undergo moments in which language itself has distantly and fleetingly touched us with its essential being.[33]

Heidegger wants to make the point that the essential being of language is also what goes unheard, language's own withdrawal. In this sense, *massklo* is a representative word of these shared orders of language.

Heidegger's work on authentic or primordial language and its effects on the human being who listens to language while speaking (to the nature of language, which withdraws as it speaks) is likely to be in the background of the connection that Celan eventually made between language and finitude, The idea that language has a stillness which allows mortality to be heard and singularity to arise, is very important for Celan's poetics and connects to Mandelstam's vision too:

> The very nature, the presencing, of language needs and uses the speaking of mortals in order to sound as the peal of stillness for the hearing of mortals. Only as men belonging with the peal of stillness are mortals able to speak in their own way in sounds.[34]

Heidegger stresses that stillness, which is an originary, non-phenomenal condition of possibility of language, can only be heard because the speakers will eventually die, and it is precisely their relationship to death that simultaneously opens singular possibilities and reveals a relation to nothingness. There is a correspondence between the nature of language and the authentic finite being which leads Celan to define each poem as 'a language fragment that has become mortal, that starts the route into nothingness … '.[35] Ultimately, for Celan and Heidegger, poetic language encounters the limits of communicability because it is the language of a person, a mortal, who speaks. To use Mandelstam's acmeist term, poetic language discloses the 'stoneness' of the speaker; but for Celan this only occurs when we address one another. In a letter from 1959 addressed to Ingeborg Bachmann, Celan writes: '"Camerado, this is no Book. Who touches this, touches a man!" I fear that the soul extensions extending to one's fingertips have long since been operationally removed from most people – in the name of human relations, incidentally … '.[36] Celan is quoting a passage from the poem 'So Long' of *Leaves of Grass*:

> Camerado, this is no book,
> Who touches this touches a man,
> (Is it night? Are we here together alone?)
> It is I you hold and who holds you,
> I spring from the pages into your arms – decease calls me forth.[37]

This poem is about reception, and the last line makes a strange or unexpected reference to finitude, which must have drawn Celan to it even more, if not

entirely, since it implies that finitude ('decease') is what drives the poetic encounter. The fingertips with which we are meant to flip the pages and silently underline the words, over and again if necessary, are the central point of Celan's poetics; they are points of contact, passage, correspondences and singularity.

In this context, meaning is not transferred from one person to another; it's neither given nor received. And what is given – awareness of finitude, the singularity of one in the difference of the other, is impossible to receive, because, like poetic language, it withdraws. In this sense his fingertips are more like the ones described by Mandelstam in 'The Word and Culture' than those of Whitman, as they seek the verges: 'Write imageless verges if you can (…) a blind man recognizes a face by barely touching it with seeing fingers'.[38]

Celan was always concerned with mourning the mass murder of the Jewish community that he belonged to and, in a very deep sense, with mourning the German language too. But the connection between the limits of communication, otherness and finitude only became core to his poetics during the period in which the ideas of *The Meridian* were starting to be developed, which is why there are many twentieth century and contemporary continental philosophers who acknowledge the way Celan's speech transgresses a metaphysical tradition centred on presence, recognition and self-sameness. Those who contribute most to these reflections are Christopher Fynsk, Philippe Lacoue-Labarthe and Jacques Derrida. In 'The Realities at Stake in a Poem: Celan's Bremen and Darmstadt Addresses', Fynsk explores the Celan-Heidegger relationship and argues that Celan goes one step further than Heidegger by relating being-towards death to being-with:

> … we may conclude that he [Celan] is pushing Heidegger's thought of finitude to the point of recognizing that the difference can only be thought as occurring or opening *in relation*, in always singular relations (and thus thought as always differing from itself).[39]

This is what makes Celan's reference to Whitman in the Bachmann letter stand out – and makes it just the right passage to describe his poetry: 'It is I you hold, and who holds you; / I spring from the pages into your arms – decease calls me forth'. This is also where the critical approach to Baudelaire's correspondences led Mandelstam and Celan to: poems as singular passageways in space and time between existences.

In the 'Editor's Preface' of *The Meridian*, it is said that the speech Celan gave in 1958 on presenting the Literary Prize of the Free Hanseatic City of Bremen is probably the first of his texts to anticipate *The Meridian*. The claim is supported with the following quote: 'Poems are also on the way in this manner: they are headed for something. Toward what? Toward something still open, still to be occupied, perhaps toward a responsive You'.[40]

This quotation stresses the question of address and is in direct dialogue with Osip Mandelstam, because this sentence comes right after Celan compares a poem to a message in a bottle: 'A poem, as a manifestation of language and thus essentially dialogue, can be a message in a bottle, sent out in the – not always hopeful – belief that somewhere and sometime it could wash up on land, on heartland perhaps'.[41] In his 1913 essay, 'On the Addressee', Mandelstam wrote:

> At a critical moment a seafarer tosses a sealed bottle into the ocean waves, containing his name and a message detailing his fate. Wandering along the dunes many years later, I happen upon it in the sand. I read the message, note the date, the last will and testament of one who has passed on. I have the right to do so. I have not opened someone else's mail. The message in the bottle was addressed to its finder. I found it. That means I have become its secret addressee.[42]

Celan's allusion to this passage has received attention by the scarce scholars who have studied their relationship. Glazova uses it to compare their different views on address and time. 'The temporality of Mandelstam's poem is (…) defined both in relation to the past and to the future. This structure perpetuates a poetic tradition which, by means of transformation, continues a 'dialogue' with authors long dead and addresses authors to come'.[43] She interprets the destinatary as an author and the temporality involved as time travel. William Waters argues that the reference to the date in Mandelstam's passage is an affirmation that 'the writer is dead' and that '[o]nce you have found the message, there will be no other addressee. In this way you become answerable for it'.[44] His aim is to relate address, reception and ethics.

I believe Mandelstam's passage points to the main issues of *The Meridian*: address, destiny and encounter. And it refers to time in two different ways: there is the vast time that comes between the critical moment in which the seafarer tosses the bottle and when it is found, and then there is the other time, more intimate, when the finder reads the message. According to Mandelstam, the anonymity of the addressee is guaranteed by the first kind of time: the distance between the seafarer and the person who finds the bottle. But the second time also involves distance: 'I read the message, note the date, the last will and testament of one who has passed on'. An existential distance opens up as address, encounter and finitude are interwoven.

The significance of poetic encounter in Celan's poetics drives him to combine and transform these ideas with Martin's Buber's reflections on dialogic address and encounter.

Buber's philosophy of dialogue differentiates two ways of relating to the world: the world to be used and the world to be met. '[T]his twofoldness runs through the whole world, through each person, each human activity',[45] which is why he ultimately says that there are two primary words: 'I-It' and

'I-Thou'. To the former correspond experience, objectivity, utility and consciousness; to the second, presentness, pure relation with spirit and all living beings. The human being moves amongst both words: '[w]ithout IT, man cannot live. But he who lives with IT alone is not a man … '.[46]

Nevertheless, for Buber the world to be met, the 'I-Thou' relation, has a mystical base: in the encounter spirit is present. Whilst the holy is present in Buber's encounter, for Celan what is present is finite temporality. Buber argued that modern individualism distanced people from the spirit, which 'is not in the I but between the I and Thou. It is not like the blood that circulates in you, but like the air in which you breathe. Man lives in the spirit if he is able to respond to this Thou. He is able to if he enters in relation with his whole being'.[47] His philosophy tried to remedy the separation amongst individuals by reflecting on the in-between space that we have in common and which he mystically calls spirit. That is where 'I' and 'Thou' are in relation. But, the 'I-Thou' relationship is discontinuous: 'It is the eternal chrysalis, the Thou [is] the eternal butterfly – except that situations do not always follow one another in clear succession, but often there is a happening profoundly twofold, confusedly entangled'.[48] Buber calls the continuous return from having been in relation, the falling back into the 'It', 'the exalted melancholy of our fate'.[49]

What probably drew Celan to Buber's reflection on the 'I and Thou' relationship is that the sphere of relation with other people takes place in language; consequently, language's capacity to set up relations is privileged over its capacity to signify:

> In the relation sphere of our life with men language is consummated as a sequence, in speech and counter speech. Here alone does the word that is formed in language meet its response. Only here does the primary word go backwards and forwards in the same form, the word of address and the word of response live in the one language, I and Thou take their stand not merely in relation but also in the solid give-and-take of talk. The moments of relation are here, and only here bound together by means of the element of speech in which they are immersed […] true address receives true response.[50]

Accordingly, relation takes place in three different spheres: nature, our life with other people, and spiritual beings. Since God is pure relation, he is present in the three of them. In the second sphere, which this passage is referring to, relation takes place in language: in speech and counter-speech. The very possibility that language has of saying 'Thou', of addressing, is extremely important for Buber since 'primary words bring out existence only by being spoken'.[51] This is very similar to how Celan ends up understanding the poem: an encounter only made possible through poetic address. For Buber, the back and forth movement between the addressed 'Thou' and the 'I' creates a sense of correspondence that makes one essential for the

appearance of the other, so the twofold nature of being is set forth: every 'Thou' is 'I-Thou' and the same goes for every 'I'.

Derrida has written significantly on Celan and addresses *The Meridian* in two complementary texts: 'Shibboleth for Paul Celan' and 'Majesties'. In the first, he creatively addresses the problem of singularity by reflecting on the significance of dates in Celan's work; specifically on the singularity and the loss of singularity they go through when they become readable. 'Majesties' is a lesser known text in which Derrida points out that the 'secret of encounter', which is where Celan says each poem is headed, is at the same time its condition of possibility, its *savoir faire*, as well as what 'in the present itself, in the very presentation of the poem (…) continues to remain secret (…) a phenomenon that does not phenomenalize itself (…) non-manifestation'.[52] This is a very valuable reading since he shows that the non-phenomenalizable in Celan's poetry doesn't have to do with the work's 'own' elements but with the work as a place of encounter.

For a poet who related Nazi Germany to a moment in which language went through a 'death bringing answerlessness', as we saw in reference to the *Bremen Address*, it is understandable that poetry would become a matter of address and reception, which is what he stresses with the image of Mandelstam's seafarer to state that a poem is 'essentially dialogic'. In fact, Celan turns writing into a matter of reading and reception, rather than creating, in the name of human relations and the back and forth movement of address: 'I, an eye / similar / to yours on each finger / probe for / a place, through which I / can wake myself toward you, / the bright / hungercandle in mouth'.[53] In these lines, which echo Whitman's and Mandelstam's references to fingertips and reading, it is not by chance that the speaker carries in his mouth a hungercandle to read with instead of a tongue to speak with. Thanks to his dialogue with Heidegger, Buber and Mandelstam in the late 50's, for Celan poetry became a candle always hungry to illuminate 'the infinite-saying of nothingness'.

Notes

1. Pierre Joris, '"Editor's Preface" to Paul Celan's', in *The Meridian. Final Version-Drafts-Materials*, trans. Pierre Joris and ed. Hereafter abbreviated *MDM*. Bernhard Böschenstein and H. Schmull (Stanford UP, 2011), p. xliii.
2. *Michael Eskin, Ethics and Dialogue in the Works of Levinas, Bakhtin, Mandel's-tham, and Celan* (Oxford UP, 2000), p. 13.
3. Although Celan was Mandelstam's first translator from Russian to German, I have not taken these translations into account to write this article since I do not speak Russian and would not be able to grasp the complete significance of the decisions made in the translation. For an indepth account of this account see the doctoral dissertation by Leeore Schnairsohn, *The Poem at the Border of Translation: Osip Mandelstam, Paul Celan, and the Lives of the*

Word (Princeton University, 2013). https://dataspace.princeton.edu/handle/88435/dsp01ns0646097 [Date accesed: 11 April 2025].

4. In *Paul Celan and Martin Heidegger. An Unresolved Conversation* (2006), James K. Lyon convincingly makes the case that most 'readers have distorted the content of the poem [Celan's "Todtnauberg"] and the entire relationship that preceded and followed it' (p. 172). He points out that scholars don't specify that when Celan visited the philosopher for the first time (and this is another point: they met two more times) in Freiburg in the summer of 1967 'he was on leave of absence from confinement in a psychiatric clinic to which he returned after the visit' (p. 160). Lyon attributes to Celan's mental disorder the fact that he changed his version of the encounter as time passed, because the first version is recorded in a letter he wrote to his wife, Gisèle Lestrange, which says: 'I hope that Heidegger will take his pen and write a few pages echoing (the conversation), that will be a warning in view of resurgent Nazism' (p. 167). For Lyon this suggests that things could not have gone as badly as we believe today.
5. Some key studies regarding Celan's connection to Martin Heidegger and Martin Buber are: Ziarek, Krzysztof, *Inflicted Language*: *Toward a Hermeneutic of Nearness. Stevens, Celan* (Albany: State University of New York Press. 1994). *Heidegger, Levinas*; James K. Lyon, *Paul Celan and Martin Heidegger. An Unresolved Conversation* (Johns Hopkins UP, 2006). Maurice Freidman, 'Paul Celan and Martin Buber: The Poetics of Dialogue and the Eclipse of God', *Religion and Literature*, 29.1 (University of Notre Dame, 1997), pp. 43–62. There are also studies on Celan from a heidegegrian perspective, such as Christopher Fynsk, 'The Realities at Stake in a Poem: Celan's Bremen and Darmstadt Addresses', in *Word Traces. Readings of Paul Celan* (The Johns Hopkins UP, 1994), pp. 159–98, and Philippe Lacoue-Labarthe, *Poetry as Experience*, trans. Andrea Tarnowski (Stanford UP, 1999). The relationship between Celan and these two philosophers is also addressed in John Felstiner's biography *Poet, Survivor, Jew* (Yale UP, 2001).
6. Paul Celan, *MDM*, p. 112.
7. Boris Gasparov, 'Poetry of the Silver Age', in *Cambridge Companion to Twentieth Century Russian Literature* (Cambridge UP, 2011), p. 2.
8. Ibid., p. 63.
9. Ibid., p. 3.
10. Ibid.
11. Osip Mandelstan, *The Collected Critical Prose and Letters*, trans. Jane Gary and Harris C. Link and ed. Jane Gary Harris (Collins Harvill, 1991), p. 128.
12. Boris Gasparov, 'Poetry of the Silver Age', p. 9.
13. Adrian Wanner, *Baudelaire in Russia* (UP of Florida, 1996), p. 174.
14. Ibid., p. 121.
15. Ibid., p. 20.
16. Ibid., p. 41.
17. Osip Mandelstan, *The Collected Critical Prose and Letters*, p. 61.
18. Boris Gasparov, 'Poetry of the Silver Age', p. 10.
19. Osip Mandelstan, *The Collected Critical Prose and Letters*, p. 64.
20. Paul Celan, *Breathturn into Timestead. The Collected Later Poetry*, trans. Pierre Joris (Farrar, Strauss and Giroux, 2014), p. 351. Hereafter abbreviated *BIT*.
21. Paul Celan, *MDM,* p. 5.
22. Ibid., p. 55.

23. Paul Celan, *Selected Poems and Prose of Paul Celan*, trans. John Felstiner (W.W. Norton & Co., 2001), p. 395. Hereafter abbreviated *SPP*.
24. Paul Celan, *MDM,* p. 70.
25. Ibid., p. 222.
26. Ibid., p. 162.
27. James K. Lyon, *Paul Celan and Martin Buber: Poetry as Dialogue* (PMLA 86, 1971), p. 114.
28. Excerpted from Selected Poems and Prose of Paul Celan by Paul Celan, translated by John Felstiner. Copyright (c) 2001 by John Felstiner. Used with permission of the publisher, W. W. Norton & Company, Inc. All rights reserved.This is the original in German: 'Käme, / käme ein Mensch, / käme ein Mensch zur Welt, heute, mit / dem Lichtbart der / Patriarchen: er dürfte, / spräch er von dieser / Zeit, er / dürfte / nur lallen und lallen, / immer-, immer- / zuzu. // ("Pallaksch. Pallaksch")' (p. 163). It is taken from the bilingual edition: Paul Celan and Obras Completas, trans. José Luis Reina Palazón (Trotta, 2007). This is the bilingual edition of Celan's poetry that is distributed in Latin America and the way I access his early poetry in German, since I am from and based in Colombia.
29. The first reference to Hölderlin's use of this word is found in Christoph Theodor Schwab's diary, written during the time he visited Hölderlin in the 1840's: 'Ich bat ihn, eine Stelle vorzulesen, er sprach aber nur unsinnige Worte, das Wort pallaksch scheint bei ihm ja zu bedeuten' (Tagebuch. Januar/Februar 14. Jan. 1841. Hölderlins Sämmtliche Werke, Große Stuttgarter Aufgabe, StA VII/3, edited by Friedrich Beißner. Verlag W. Kohlhammer. Stuttgart, 1974. p. 203). The ambivalence of the word's meaning to mean both yes and no is mentioned in Wilhelm Michel's biography of the poet: Das Leben Friedrich Hölderlins. Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft. Darmstadt 1963.
30. Agamben Giorigio, *Remnants of Auschwitz. The Witness and the Archive*, trans. Daniel Heller-Roazen (Zone Books, 1999), p. 38.
31. Jacques Derrida, 'Poetics and Politics of Witnessing', in Thomas Dutoit and Outi Pasanen (eds), *Sovereignties in Question: The Poetics of Paul Celan* (Fordham UP, 2005), p. 66.
32. This essay was included in *On the Way to Language*, which Heidegger published in 1959 and sent to Celan personally. The poet recorded reading it that same year, only one before *The Meridian* was composed.
33. Martin Heidegger, 'The Nature of Language', in *On The Way to Language*, trans. Peter D. Hertz (Harper and Row, 2003), p. 59.
34. Martin Heidegger, 'Language', in *Poetry, Language, Thought*, trans. Albert Hofstadter (Harper and Row, 2001), p. 205.
35. Paul Celan, *MDM*, p. 199.
36. Ingeborg Bachmann and Paul Celan, *Correspondence* (Seagull Books, 2010), p. 174.
37. Walt Whitman, 'So Long!' in *Leaves of Grass*: *A Textual Variorum of the Printed Poems: 1860–1867* (New York UP, 1980), p. 824.
38. Osip Mandelstan, *The Collected Critical Prose and Letters*, p. 116.
39. Christopher Fynsk, 'The Realities at Stake in a Poem: Celan's Bremen and Darmstadt Addresses', in *Word Traces. Readings of Paul Celan* (The Johns Hopkins UP, 1994), p. 173.
40. Paul Celan cited by Pierre Joris in 'Editor's Preface', *MDM*, p. xiv.
41. Paul Celan, *SPP*, p. 396.

42. Osip Mandelstan, *The Collected Critical Prose and Letters*, p. 68.
43. Anna Glazova, 'Poetry of Bringing about Presence: Paul Celan Translates OsipMandelstam', in *MLN 123.5* (The Johns Hopkins UP, 2008), p. 6.
44. William Waters, 'Poetic Address and Intimate Reading: The Offered Hand', in Mara Scanlon and Chad Engbers (eds), *Poetry and Dialogism* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2014), pp. 104–5.
45. Martin Buber, *I and Thou*, trans. Ronald Gregor Smith (Scribner Classics, 2000), p. 8.
46. Ibid., p. 44.
47. Ibid., p. 49.
48. Ibid., p. 31.
49. Ibid., p. 30.
50. Ibid., p. 99.
51. Ibid., p. 19.
52. Jacques Derrida, 'Majesties', in Thomas Dutoit and Outi Pasanen (eds), *Sovereignties in Question: The Poetics of Paul Celan* (Fordham UP, 2005), p. 114.
53. Paul Celan, *BIT*, p. 3. This is a fragment of the second poem of *Atemwende* or *Breathturn*, which starts: 'By the undreamt, etched … '. The fragment in German: ' … ich, ein deinem/ gleichendes / Aug an jedem der Finger, / abtaste nach / einer Stelle, durch die ich / mich zu dir heranwachen kann, / die helle / Hungerkerze im Mund' (*BIT*, p. 2).

Disclosure statement

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